

Zoho and we need technology leaders committed to the idea of relocating there," he says.

Some 15-20 per cent of Zoho's engineers have no college degrees. They are from the Zoho Schools of Learning set up in 2004, where rural students are taught software development, given a stipend and assured of employment in the company.

Launched as AdventNet Inc. in 1996 and rechristened Zoho Corporation in 2009, the company recently announced that it has crossed the $1 billion (Rs 8,100 crore) milestone in annual revenue. Vembu was awarded the Padma Shri last year and also appointed member of the National Security Advisory Board.

-Anilesh S. Mahajan

Ventures, a platform for high net worth individuals engaged in impact investing. Validation came from another source, the Hurun India Report, which counted 178 people from small towns and cities among the 1,036 individuals whose wealth exceeded Rs 1,000 crore (see *A Rich Countryside*).

A Breed Apart

An arm of the UK-based Hurun Report, a research, luxury publishing and events group, Hurun India has been compiling an annual India Rich List for the past 10 years. While its first list in 2012 had just about a hundred names, the 2022 edition listed more than a thousand people who had a net worth of Rs 1,000 crore-plus, a 10-fold growth. And small town tycoons made up 17 per cent of the total number of entrepreneurs. Engaged in businesses ranging from manufacturing to financial services to packaged foods to even gems and jewellery, the total wealth of these self-made businessmen stood at Rs 6.37 lakh crore as of March 2022, higher than India's defence budget of Rs 5.25 lakh crore for 2022-23. Of course, there's every possibility that we are undercounting the Rs 1,000 crore club. The list, says Hurun India and Middle East founder Anas Rahman Junaid, though rigorously compiled via extensive research into annual reports of listed companies and supported by direct information from the companies concerned, perhaps captures only a third of such wealth creators. There could thus be at least 3,000 individuals in India who qualify for the Rs 1,000 crore and above bracket. A good number of these could be from India's small towns. Since most of these Hurun listers own companies that are listed on the stock exchanges, a major chunk (90 per cent) of their wealth is assessed on the basis of the shares they hold in their respective firms. Additional wealth is ascertained on the basis of their personal assets, share sales and annual dividends.

That entrepreneurial energies in India are not restricted to its bigger towns is something we have always known. A survey conducted by the Economist Intelligence Unit (EIU) in January 2020 only confirmed the trend when a handful of small cities in South India secured a place on the list of the world's